Development, which published a report in 1987 called “Our Common Future.” Contributing experts, including scientists, agriculturalists, foreign ministers, technologists, and economists, made it clear that the future of humans relied on balancing ecology and economics in a way that was sustainable and fair for all nations around the world. Key areas in the struggle for a sustainably managed Earth are use of fossil fuels, deforestation, and water management.

Five years later, at the 1992 Earth Summit in Rio de Janeiro, 172 nations signed environmental resolutions. Among them was Agenda 21, a plan for governments to work together to protect natural resources and the environment. However, implementing changes has proved difficult, and subsequent Earth summits have called for better international cooperation in order to achieve goals set.

Peak oil

Fossil fuels are among the world’s most highly prized resources. People have become increasingly reliant on oil, squandering it to create a lifestyle that is ultimately unsustainable. The oil crises of the 1970s highlighted how dependent industrialized nations were on an economically viable supply. With this came, too, the realization that oil is a finite resource. Scientists had already considered the problem and calculated the date when the supply of oil would peak, before it ran out or became uneconomical to extract. In 1974 the peak oil date was predicted to be 1995, with the caveat that there were several potential variables and unknowns such as consumption rates, available technology, and reserves yet to be discovered. In the early 21st century, new dates were given, some extending the timeline for oil to 2030 or beyond. In 2011, however, US environmentalist Bill McKibben declared that calculating a peak oil date was pointless; if all known oil reserves were burned, the carbon produced would be five times the amount required to heat the planet by 3.6°F (2°C)—the “safe” temperature limit that